

Ten Effective and Efficient Open Source Firewalls

A firewall protects a network from unwanted intrusions. Open source provides many effective firewalls. Let's take a look at some of the best among them.



In this era of hackers and spammers, security is paramount. We need to implement reliable firewalls to protect our business networks. A firewall works as a security guard between internal and external networks. It inspects everything coming to and going from a network, and controls the network traffic by implementing security rules.

Some of the best open source firewalls

pfSense

pfSense is a free and powerful open source firewall used mainly for FreeBSD servers. It is based on stateful packet filtering. It has a wide range of features that are normally only found in very expensive firewalls. Figure 1 lists a few features of pfSense.

ClearOS

ClearOS is a powerful firewall that provides us the tools we need to run a network, and also gives us the option to scale up as and when required. It is a modular operating system that runs in a virtual environment or on some dedicated hardware in the home, office, etc. Solutions provided by ClearOS are described in Figure 2.

ClearOS installation is very straightforward and painless. Once the installation is done and we've got into the Web-based administration system, we can easily familiarise

ourselves with it to set up the firewall rules quickly. The most important feature of ClearOS is usability. It is a simple, easy and clean way to manage firewall rules, settings, etc.

Untangle

Untangle is an easy-to-use, easy-to-install, lightweight firewall OS. It provides a way to protect and monitor network traffic.

Features

- Network services: It enables us to manage DNS services like DHCP. We can apply NAT rules, router configurations, etc. It can be used as an add-on in transparent bridge mode.
- It has a simple GUI user interface.
- Content filtering: It enables us to filter the traffic based on groups, MIME, file extensions and file type. We can generate different reports for Web traffic.
- Security services: Virus, spam and ad blockers are provided by Untangle.
- Firewall: We can allow or block traffic from some specific IP addresses or port numbers.
- VPN: It has an open VPN.
- Reports: We can view different reports on topics like the top users, top sites used, top downloads, etc.